

Recent

Along with the causes of war and other forms of violence, the psychological consequences of violence, to both victims and perpetrators, has received attention from peace psychologists. A major development occurred in 1980, when the long-standing observations of "battle fatigue" and "war neurosis" congealed into the concept of Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD). This was formally defined in the diagnostic manuals of the American Psychiatric Association (1987, 1994), and the World Health Organization (1992). An explosion of research into the disorder and its symptoms ensued and is still lively. It was expanded from veterans to refugees and other direct victims of war and to crime victims. It applies to any form of trauma, but it has been clear from experience that PTSD symptoms tend to be more severe when the trauma is inflicted by another person, as opposed to accident or natural disaster. In 1990, Kulka and colleagues published the results of a major United States government study showing that full and partial PTSD were in fact widespread among American veterans of the war in Vietnam. More recently, the idea that being the agent that causes trauma -- that is, killing or committing other direct violence -- can also lead to PTSD symptoms has received some attention ([MacNair, 2002](#)).

In 1982, Psychologists for Social Responsibility (PsySR) was founded and focused on preventing nuclear war. It currently remains one of the major grass-roots networks of psychologists active in peace concerns in the United States.

Organizationally, it was in 1988 that Division 48, the "Society for the Study of Peace, Conflict, and Violence: Peace Psychology Division of the American Psychological Association." was established by vote of the APA Council, a vote that James Polyson and Michael Wessells had especially pushed for (Jacobs, 1989). It had failed the previous year on grounds that APA already had outlets for peace psychology, especially SPSSI. However, SPSSI deals with a much wider range of issues. Division 48 is still large and active. The Division publishes a journal devoted to peace psychology, *Peace and Conflict: Journal of Peace Psychology*, which first appeared in 1995.

In 1989, the first International Symposium on the Contributions of Psychology to Peace was held in Bulgaria and attracted peace psychologists from a variety of countries. The organization continued to hold symposiums every other year in Germany, the United States, South Africa, Australia, Costa Rica, the Philippines, and a continuing dispersion of venues. In 1994 UNESCO (United Nations Education, Scientific & Cultural Organization) commissioned a background paper by the Committee for the Psychological Study of Peace of the International Union of Psychological Science, highlighting the contributions psychology can make to peace and social justice.

Researchers have identified and investigated many of the cognitive processes behind various forms of violence. Albert Bandura and his colleagues argued that the most inhumane behavior comes from psychological processes by which original ideas of moral conduct are disengaged. They suggested that the idea that these "moral disengagement" mechanisms remove inhibitions has been extensively documented in historical atrocities, and confirmed in laboratory studies of punitive behavior (Bandura, Barbanelli, Caprara, & Pastorelli, 1996). The most effective of these mechanisms is the cognitive transformation of the reprehensible conduct into good conduct.

Abuse of medicine is a peculiar form of violence in that it is more difficult to recognize as violence. The same acts of sticking needles into arms or causing someone to become unconscious and then cutting them would be violence outside the context of inoculations and surgery. Since they are seen as beneficial to the person to whom they are voluntarily done, they are medicine instead. However, if that beneficence is removed, they become simple violence.

Still controversial are the areas of abortion and assisted suicide, whether these are matters of autonomy with their absence being medical

neglect, or whether these are matters of killing and therefore, under a consistent life ethic, are connected to other forms of killing in causation and effect.

Throughout the decades, various forms of peace education have developed. In 1970, for example, Brazilian Paulo Friere published *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, detailing an adult education method called "conscientization." Adults participating in this education strategy study violence and develop and implement nonviolent alternatives. In addition to the original approaches of international perspectives which teach people to be global citizens and regard those in other cultures with understanding, an especially popular approach has been teaching children conflict resolution and other violence prevention skills. There have been moral and character and religious approaches, nonviolence, environmental, and human rights approaches, along with public education on specific public policy issues, use of artistic media, and of course the interdisciplinary area of peace studies itself along with disciplines such as peace psychology. Activity in this area is quite extensive. The many studies on effectiveness of programs with children are showing encouraging results. Textbooks focusing specifically on the entire field of peace psychology itself are a more recent development.

This short survey shows several trends in peace psychology. In earlier years, the focus was on war and related military matters, with international policies and understandings of different cultures. A major concern of early statements and writings was to dispel the idea that violence and aggression are part of human nature and that war in general is therefore inevitable.

Peace psychology is an area that is especially sensitive to political events. Before World War I, most focus was on preventing the kind of wars common to the nineteenth century, with much effort expended in trying to establish that war was actually undesirable. Both world wars understandably brought about more interest in the question of war prevention.

The long interest in terrorism was intensified by the September 11, 2001 attacks and is likely to lead to much more scholarship in that area. Many areas of peace psychology have remained constant throughout, but other areas have had to adapt to new realities in a field where events in the news and grassroots activities in various populations are major sources of primary material.

In the case of peace psychology, the definitions and events that have occurred have added threads of topics that interweave with each other and interweave also with the remainder of psychology.